

# Where the City website costs residents time — and how to fix it

A before/after audit and proposal for the Office of Mayor Justin C. Brasch

City of White Plains, New York · Prepared June 2026

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## The short version

The City's current website (cityofwhiteplains.com) runs on CivicPlus — a capable but heavily templated platform. The problem isn't that it looks dated. It's that everyday resident tasks take longer than they should, key information is locked inside PDFs, and the site does not yet meet the accessibility standard now legally binding on the City under the Americans with Disabilities Act.

This document pairs each problem with a working fix. Every fix below is already built and running as a live, static prototype:

<https://never-nude.github.io/cityofwhiteplains1/>

The prototype is plain HTML and CSS — no licensing, no proprietary CMS, no server to maintain. It can be hosted anywhere, including for free. It is a proof of work; news items and figures are illustrative but grounded in real White Plains specifics. Anything requiring a real backend is clearly stubbed, not faked.

## Why accessibility is now a deadline, not a nicety

In April 2024 the U.S. Department of Justice issued a final rule under Title II of the ADA establishing WCAG 2.1 Level AA as the binding technical standard for the websites and mobile apps of state and local governments. In April 2026 DOJ extended the original compliance dates by one year.

White Plains has a 2020 Census population of **59,559** — above the 50,000 threshold — placing the City in the larger-entity tier with a compliance deadline of **April 26, 2027**. That is under a year away.

The exposure is concrete. When a public website fails WCAG 2.1 AA — low contrast, no keyboard focus, unlabeled controls, scanned PDFs a screen reader can't read — it is both a barrier to residents with disabilities and a documented basis for ADA complaints against the municipality. PDFs in particular are one of the most common sources of public-sector accessibility findings. The prototype is built to WCAG 2.1 AA from the ground up; meeting the standard before the deadline is far cheaper than remediating under a complaint.

## The audit: seven problems, seven fixes

### ***1. Search that doesn't know what residents need***

**Where the current site costs residents.** Templated civic search returns a long, flat list with no sense of priority — a resident searching "taxes" scans past minutes and archived news to find the link that lets them pay, then gives up and calls City Hall.

**The fix.** A client-side index that ranks resident tasks first: "tax," "permit," or "pool" surface Pay property taxes, Apply for a building permit, Pool hours — with live autocomplete and a clean results page. No search server to run.

**Why it matters.** The fastest path to the task is the entire job of a city website. Every completed search is a call City Hall didn't take.

### ***2. A mobile experience for how residents actually browse***

**Where the current site costs residents.** Most local-government traffic is on phones. Templated menus are an afterthought and the most-needed tasks sit several taps deep.

**The fix.** A real slide-in menu with proper focus handling, plus a persistent bottom task bar on phones carrying the top actions — Pay, Pools, Report, Search — one tap away. Accessible tap-target sizes; tested at 380px.

**Why it matters.** If the site is hard to use one-handed on a phone, it is hard to use, full stop.

### ***3. Accessibility built in, not bolted on***

**Where the current site costs residents.** Common WCAG failures on civic sites: insufficient contrast, no visible keyboard focus, missing labels, data tables without headers, documents without text alternatives. Each is a barrier and, under the Title II rule, a compliance gap.

**The fix.** Audited and corrected for WCAG 2.1 AA: contrast verified against AA thresholds, a visible focus indicator on every control, skip links and landmarks on every page, ARIA labels, accessible tables, and reduced-motion support.

**Why it matters.** This is the item with legal teeth — and the one that decides whether every resident can use the site.

### ***4. Real Spanish, not a translate widget***

**Where the current site costs residents.** Many civic sites rely on a Google Translate widget. Machine translation of civic terms ("assessment," "lien," "FOIL," "exemption") is unreliable, breaks layout, and is itself an accessibility problem.

**The fix.** A built-in English/Spanish toggle with curated, civically correct Spanish for the homepage and Pay & Apply page plus chrome everywhere; the choice persists through the visit.

**Why it matters.** A meaningful share of residents speak Spanish at home. Reliable translation of the pages people use is equal access — and aligns with the City's language-access obligations.

## ***5. Stop burying public information in PDFs***

**Where the current site costs residents.** Agendas, minutes, and notices are posted as PDFs — often scanned. They're slow on a phone, don't reflow, are frequently unreadable by screen readers, and don't surface in search.

**The fix.** A minutes page that presents a Common Council meeting as searchable, mobile-friendly, accessible web text — with a table of contents and accessible vote table — and a "Download PDF" alongside for anyone who wants it.

**Why it matters.** Public records should be genuinely public: findable and readable by everyone, on any device. The PDF stays available; it just stops being the only option.

## ***6. An alert system that works like an emergency tool***

**Where the current site costs residents.** A static notice bar with no severity, timestamp, or dismissal gives residents no way to tell a routine note from an emergency, or to trust it's current.

**The fix.** Severity levels (notice / warning / emergency), a timestamp on each alert, per-visit dismissal, and a working "Subscribe to alerts" sign-up (email/SMS/severity). Delivery is stubbed and on the roadmap.

**Why it matters.** During a water-main break or a storm, clarity and credibility are the product. The alert bar has to be unambiguous.

## ***7. Fast, durable, and inexpensive to run***

**Where the current site costs residents.** A proprietary CMS means ongoing license cost, vendor lock-in, and a heavier, slower page.

**The fix.** Static HTML/CSS with small vanilla-JavaScript enhancements — no framework, no build, no database. It loads fast, has little to break, and can be hosted anywhere (currently free on GitHub Pages).

**Why it matters.** Public money and resilience both argue for the lightest thing that does the job well.

## **What would still need a backend**

Honesty matters in a pitch. The prototype stubs — does not fake — the pieces that genuinely require server infrastructure: real payment processing; real alert delivery (email/SMS) and subscriber management; live form intake (permits, problem reports, FOIL); and authenticated resident accounts. Each is listed in the project README under "Roadmap / requires backend." The UI is built and convincing so the experience can be evaluated now; the integrations would follow.

## **The ask**

A short working session to walk the Mayor's office through the live prototype on a phone and a laptop, and to scope what a production version — meeting the April 2027 ADA deadline — would take. The hard design and accessibility work is already demonstrated. The next decision is whether the City wants its website measured by how fast a resident gets something done.

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## **Sources**

DOJ ADA Title II web/mobile rule and timeline — <https://www.ada.gov/resources/web-rule-first-steps/>

One-year extension of Title II deadlines (April 2026) —

<https://www.venable.com/insights/publications/2026/04/ada-title-ii-website-accessibility-regulations>

White Plains population, 2020 Census (59,559) — [https://data.census.gov/profile/White\\_Plains\\_city,\\_New\\_York](https://data.census.gov/profile/White_Plains_city,_New_York)

Current City website platform (CivicPlus) — <https://www.cityofwhiteplains.com/>

Concept prepared independently. Not an official City of White Plains website or communication.